

grew famous and tolerably well off, taking aerial acrobatics to new heights in highly publicized “barnstorming” displays that drew huge crowds.

With no safety regulations in place, barnstormers developed an astonishingly risky repertoire, adding to the standard stunts of the aerobatic pilot a whole range of circus tricks such as wing-walking, crossing from one airplane to another in flight, hanging by a trapeze underneath the plane, or apparent death falls avoided by a parachute opening at the last moment. Since audiences were not prepared to wait for a chance accident to liven up the day, the pilots staged pleasingly spectacular crashes as part of the show. The risk of death or crippling injury was accepted as part of the show.

Setting new targets

Despite the rundown state of aviation, the public’s fascination with flight remained intense. As before the war, cash prizes were made available by “air-minded” press magnates and other wealthy individuals for record-breaking long-distance flights. But now, after the rapid improvements in aircraft performance brought by the war, the flights were to far more distant destinations. No one was impressed any longer by flights between European cities or

DAREDEVIL STUNTS

This wing-walker is bracing himself to leap from one airplane to another during a 1926 barnstorming show. After the war, many unemployed pilots (including Charles Lindbergh) toured the US, thrilling small-town America with their daredevil stunts. Unfortunately, the barnstormers also reinforced the public’s belief that airplanes were dangerous, hindering the efforts of entrepreneurs trying to develop passenger airlines.

